

11

Early e4 Deviations

Meet Bg5, Bd3, Nge2, and unusual development with principles



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

Handle rare move orders by identifying their purpose rather than memorizing names.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate Black's candidates, find White's strongest reply, and choose the resulting structure you understand. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 061 | PAGE 4

Decode: Early Bg5*An unusual move matters through the plan it enables.*

LESSON 062 | PAGE 8

Play: Early Bg5*An unusual move matters through the plan it enables.*

LESSON 063 | PAGE 12

Decode: The Bd3 setup*When White's pieces crowd one wing, open the center if your king is safer.*

LESSON 064 | PAGE 16

Play: The Bd3 setup*When White's pieces crowd one wing, open the center if your king is safer.*

LESSON 065 | PAGE 20

Decode: The Nge2 clamp*A useful hook is one your pieces can attack.*

LESSON 066 | PAGE 24

Play: The Nge2 clamp*A useful hook is one your pieces can attack.***VOLUME OBJECTIVE**

Handle rare move orders by identifying their purpose rather than memorizing names.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Early Bg5

**WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS**

White uses the bishop to influence d8-h4 and slow the natural ...e5 break.

DECISION RULE

Read the king placement before choosing which wing to open.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Counter with ...c5, question d4, and keep the knight routes flexible.

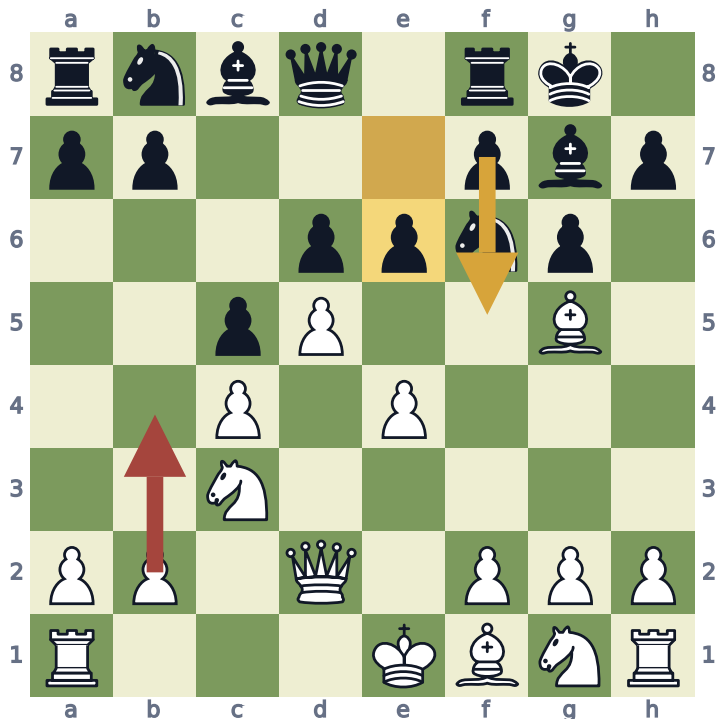
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White may castle long and begin h4-h5.

MEMORY RULE | An unusual move matters through the plan it enables.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

White uses the bishop to influence d8-h4 and slow the natural ...e5 break.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Counter with ...c5, question d4, and keep the knight routes flexible.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White may castle long and begin h4-h5.

FAILURE MODE

Copying a closed-center attack before the center is closed can expose Black.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Read the king placement before choosing which wing to open. Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

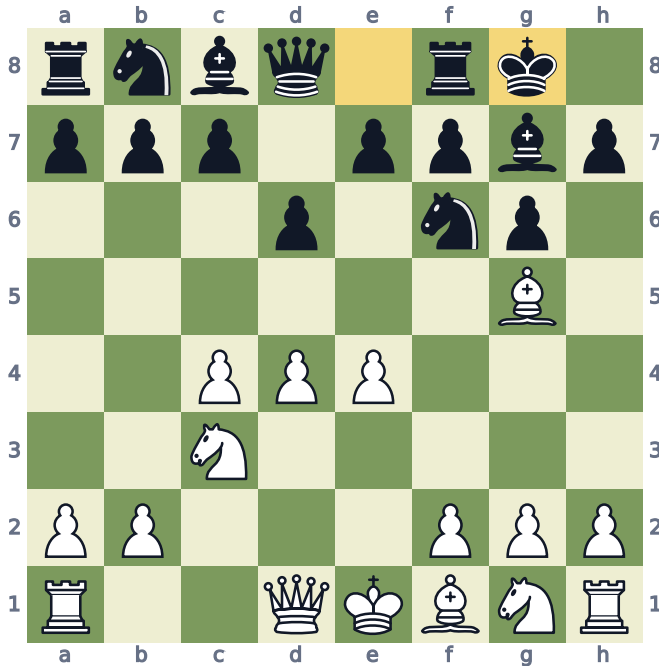
RULE | An unusual move matters through the plan it enables.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Bg5 O-O 6. Qd2 c5 7. d5 e6



- Nc3: White reroutes a knight toward c3; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- Bg7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- e4: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- Bg5: White changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the central decision can now become concrete.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

White uses the bishop to influence d8-h4 and slow the natural ...e5 break.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Read the king placement before choosing which wing to open. White's resistance is: White may castle long and begin h4-h5. The line fails as a template when: Copying a closed-center attack before the center is closed can expose Black.

STORE THIS | An unusual move matters through the plan it enables.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

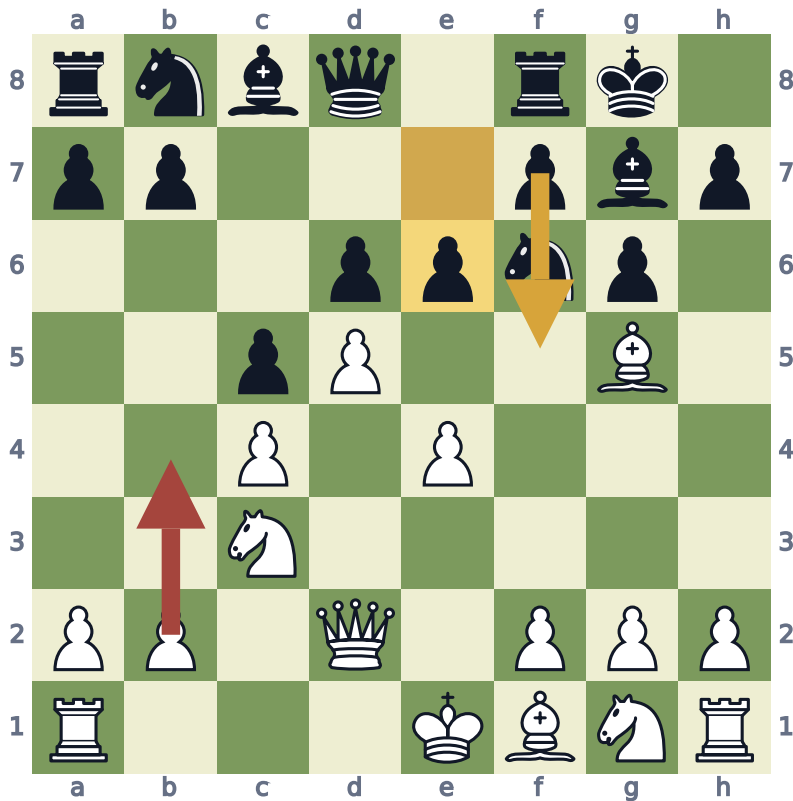
1. White uses the bishop to influence d8-h4 and slow the natural ...e5 break. 2. Counter with ...c5, question d4, and keep the knight routes flexible. 3. White may castle long and begin h4-h5. 4. Read the king placement before choosing which wing to open. 5. Copying a closed-center attack before the center is closed can expose Black.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 10 plies from memory, then replay: 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Bg5 O-O

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Early Bg5



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

White uses the bishop to influence d8-h4 and slow the natural ...e5 break.

DECISION RULE

Read the king placement before choosing which wing to open.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

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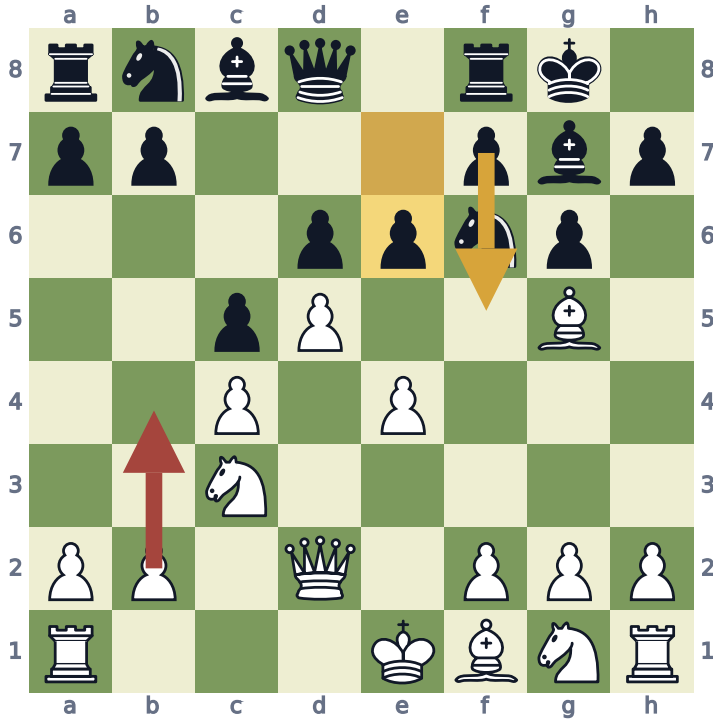
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White uses the bishop to influence d8-h4 and slow the natural ...e5 break.

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

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White may castle long and begin h4-h5.

FAILURE MODE

Copying a closed-center attack before the center is closed can expose Black.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Read the king placement before choosing which wing to open. Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

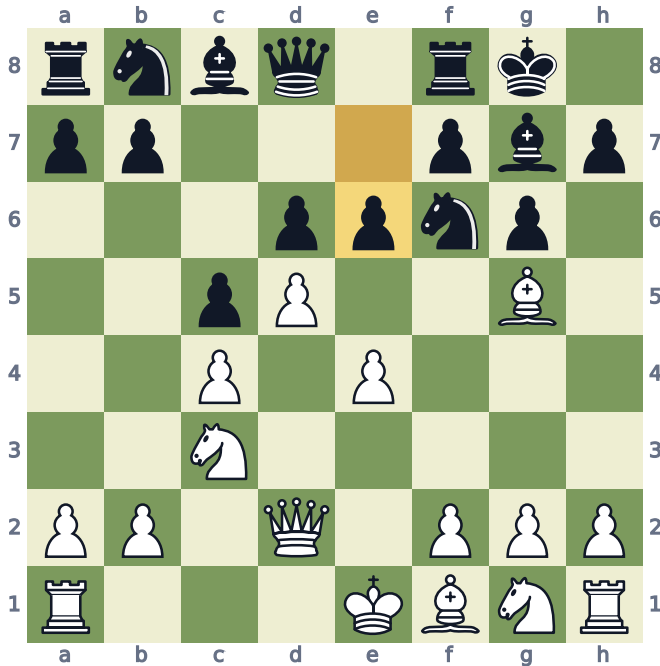
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Bg5 O-O 6. Qd2 c5 7. d5 e6



- Bg5: White changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the central decision can now become concrete.
- Qd2: White coordinates several plans, but the queen's safety and the opponent's forcing reply must be checked.
- c5: Black attacks the center from the flank and invites a Benoni-like transformation.
- d5: White claims space or creates a break that changes Black's available time and squares.
- e6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

White uses the bishop to influence d8-h4 and slow the natural ...e5 break.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Read the king placement before choosing which wing to open. White's resistance is: White may castle long and begin h4-h5. The line fails as a template when: Copying a closed-center attack before the center is closed can expose Black.

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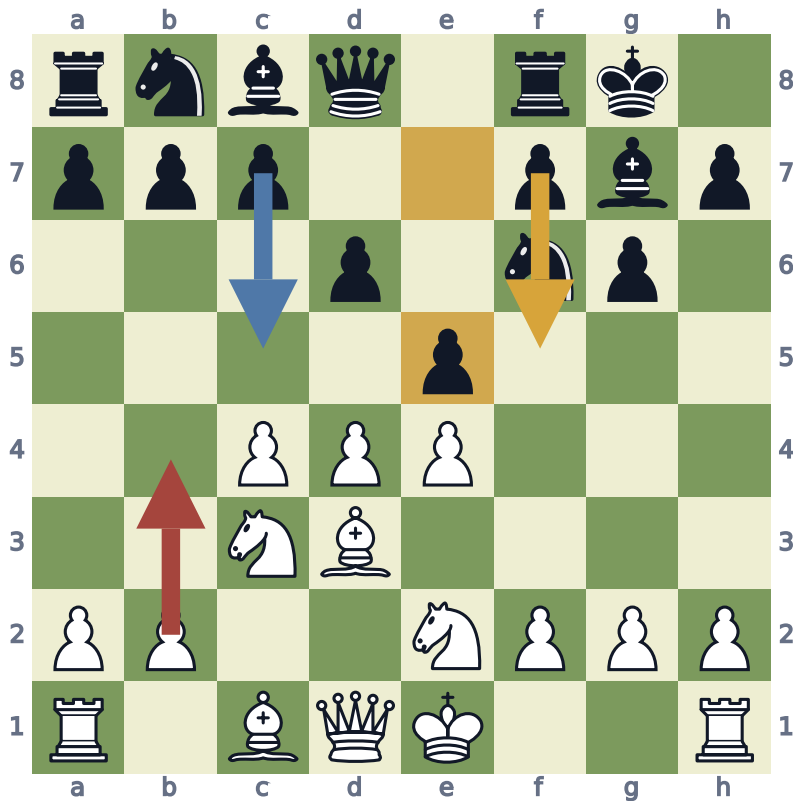
1. White uses the bishop to influence d8-h4 and slow the natural ...e5 break. 2. Counter with ...c5, question d4, and keep the knight routes flexible. 3. White may castle long and begin h4-h5. 4. Read the king placement before choosing which wing to open. 5. Copying a closed-center attack before the center is closed can expose Black.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. Bg5 O-O 6. Qd2 c5 7. d5 e6

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The Bd3 setup

**WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS**

Bd3 supports the kingside and Nge2 preserves f-pawn mobility, but the pieces can obstruct one another.

DECISION RULE

Decide whether opening the center exploits White's slower kingside development.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Challenge the center and make White prove that the setup can coordinate.

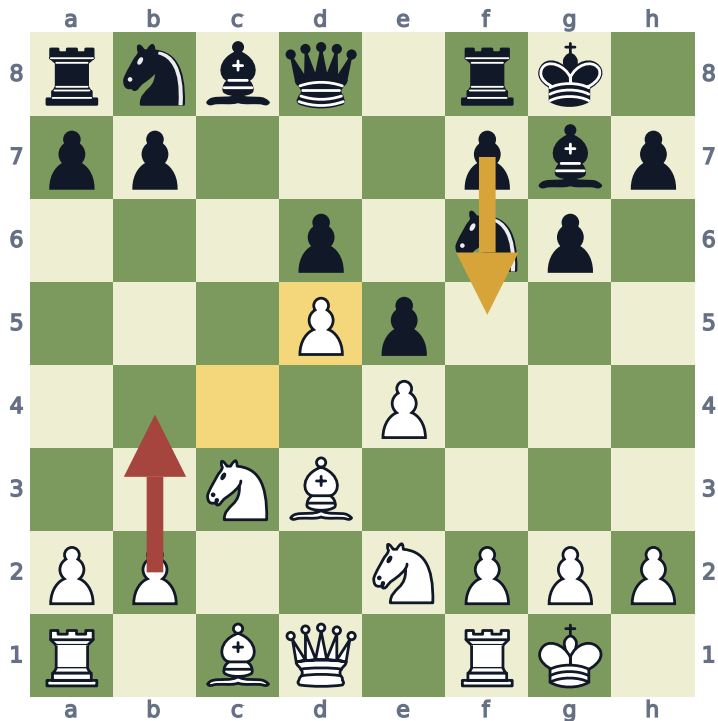
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White may play f3 or f4 and seek a direct kingside expansion.

MEMORY RULE | When White's pieces crowd one wing, open the center if your king is safer.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Bd3 supports the kingside and Nge2 preserves f-pawn mobility, but the pieces can obstruct one another.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Challenge the center and make White prove that the setup can coordinate.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White may play f3 or f4 and seek a direct kingside expansion.

FAILURE MODE

Closing automatically may give White time to arrange the attack.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Decide whether opening the center exploits White's slower kingside development. Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

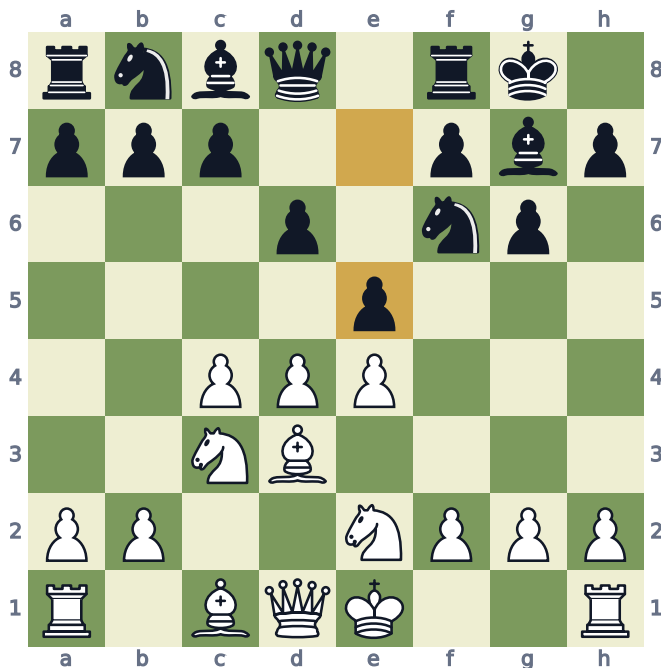
RULE | When White's pieces crowd one wing, open the center if your king is safer.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Bd3 O-O 6. Nge2 e5 7. d5 c6 8. O-O cxd5 9. cxd5



- e4: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- Bd3: White changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the central decision can now become concrete.
- Nge2: White reroutes a knight toward e2; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- e5: Black makes direct central contact and asks whether White will close, capture, or maintain tension.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Bd3 supports the kingside and Nge2 preserves f-pawn mobility, but the pieces can obstruct one another.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Decide whether opening the center exploits White's slower kingside development. White's resistance is: White may play f3 or f4 and seek a direct kingside expansion. The line fails as a template when: Closing automatically may give White time to arrange the attack.

STORE THIS | When White's pieces crowd one wing, open the center if your king is safer.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

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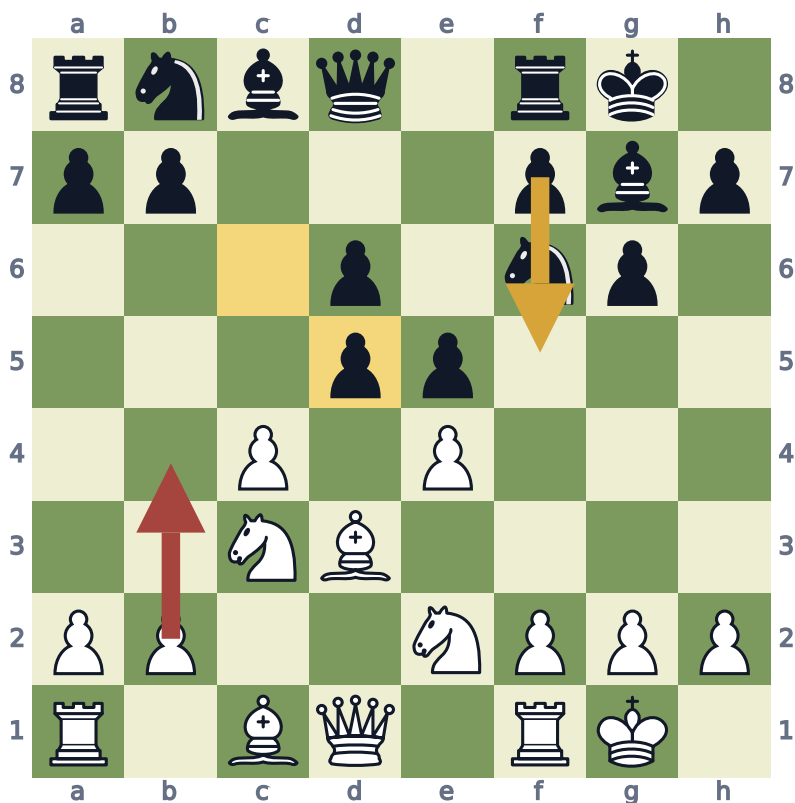
1. Bd3 supports the kingside and Nge2 preserves f-pawn mobility, but the pieces can obstruct one another. 2. Challenge the center and make White prove that the setup can coordinate. 3. White may play f3 or f4 and seek a direct kingside expansion. 4. Decide whether opening the center exploits White's slower kingside development. 5. Closing automatically may give White time to arrange the attack.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. e4 d6 5. Bd3 O-O 6. Nge2 e5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The Bd3 setup



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Bd3 supports the kingside and Nge2 preserves f-pawn mobility, but the pieces can obstruct one another.

DECISION RULE

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SIDE TO MOVE

White

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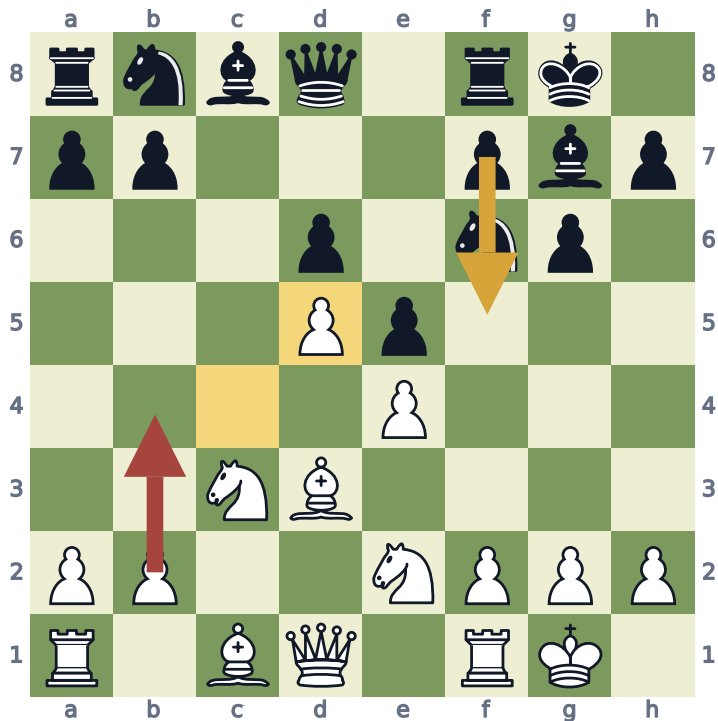
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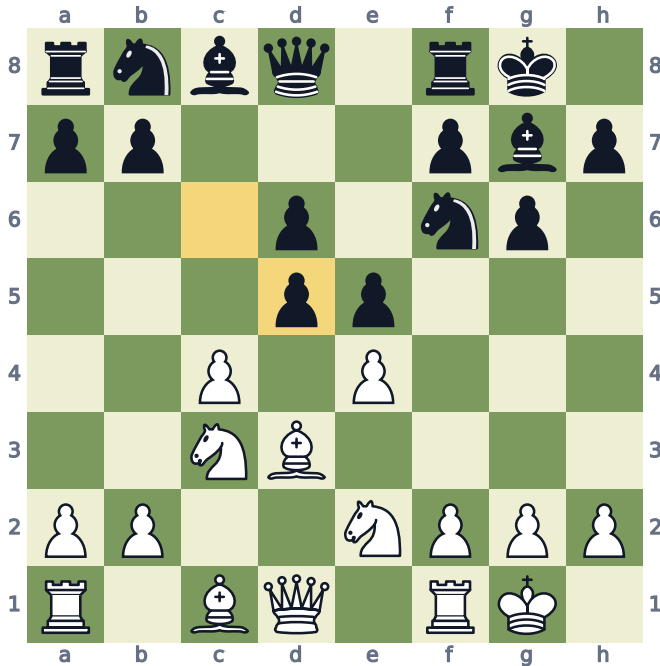
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Move-by-move meaning

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- Nge2: White reroutes a knight toward e2; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- e5: Black makes direct central contact and asks whether White will close, capture, or maintain tension.
- d5: White claims space or creates a break that changes Black's available time and squares.
- c6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the central decision can now become concrete.
- cxd5: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.

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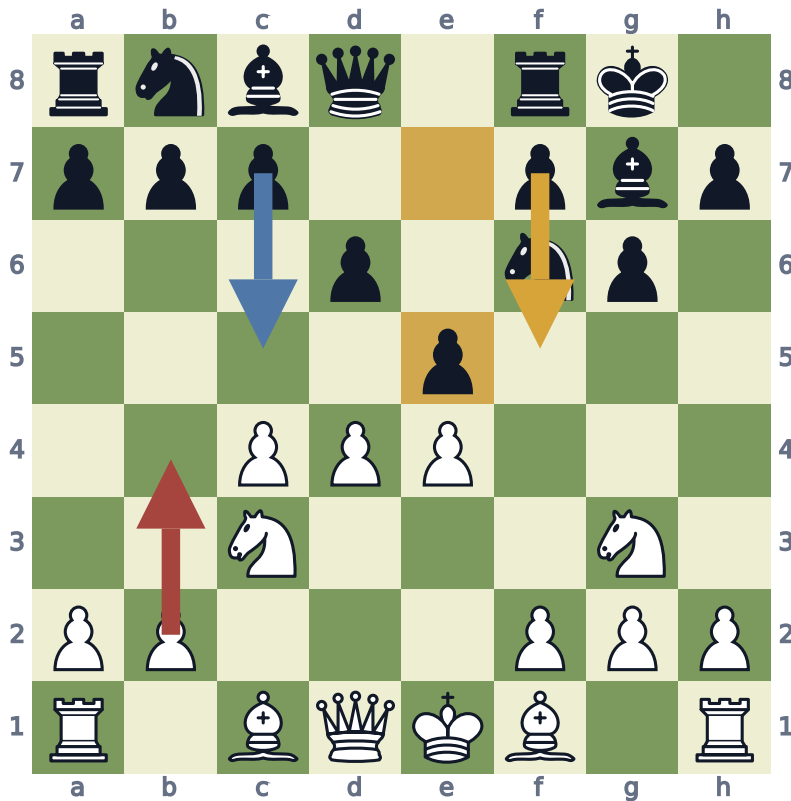
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Nge2 e5 7. d5 c6 8. O-O cxd5

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The Nge2 clamp

**WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS**

Nge2-g3 supports f5 and h5 ideas while leaving the f-pawn free, but the knight can become a target.

DECISION RULE

Judge ...h5 by whether it fixes a target or merely creates one on g6.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Use ...h5 and queen coordination to limit White's kingside space while preserving central play.

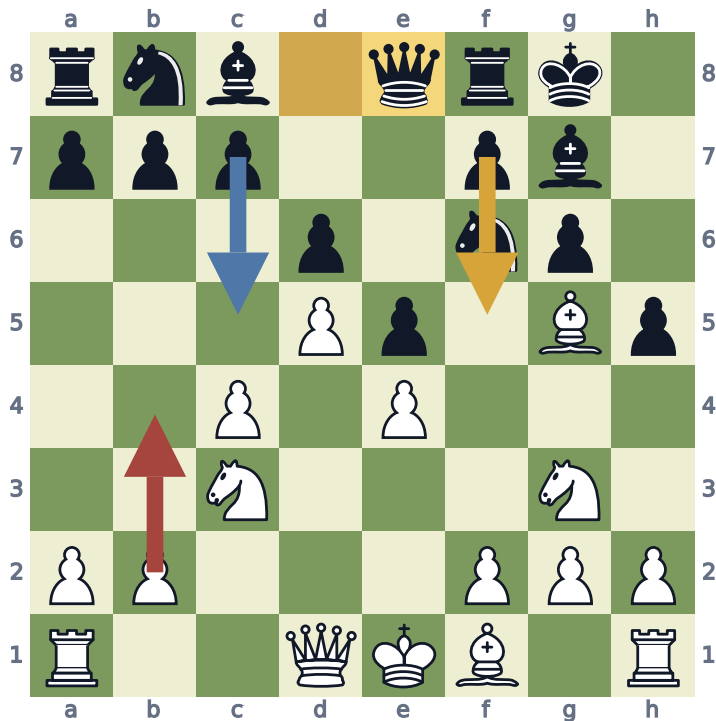
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White seeks h4, Be2, and a slow bind.

MEMORY RULE | A useful hook is one your pieces can attack.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Nge2-g3 supports f5 and h5 ideas while leaving the f-pawn free, but the knight can become a target.

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White seeks h4, Be2, and a slow bind.

FAILURE MODE

Flank prevention without central activity can become self-restraint.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Judge ...h5 by whether it fixes a target or merely creates one on g6. Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

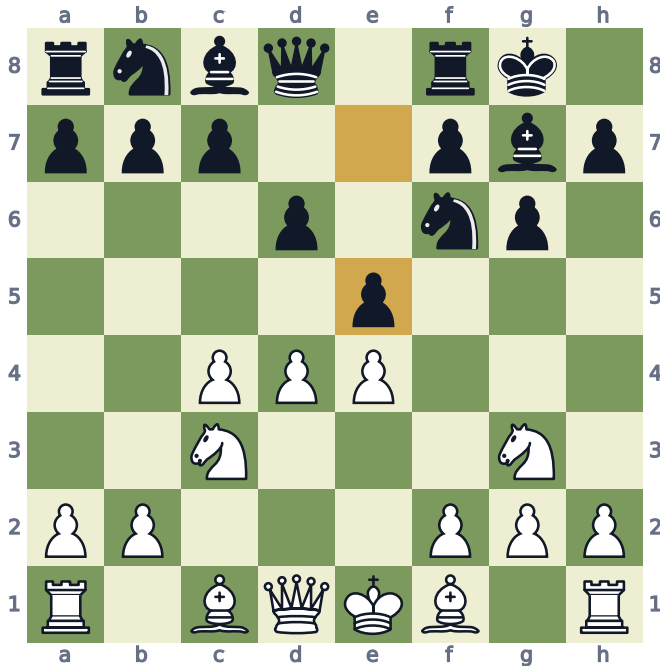
RULE | A useful hook is one your pieces can attack.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nge2 O-O 6. Ng3 e5 7. d5 h5 8. Bg5 Qe8



- e4: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- Nge2: White reroutes a knight toward e2; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the central decision can now become concrete.
- Ng3: White reroutes a knight toward g3; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- e5: Black makes direct central contact and asks whether White will close, capture, or maintain tension.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Nge2-g3 supports f5 and h5 ideas while leaving the f-pawn free, but the knight can become a target.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Judge ...h5 by whether it fixes a target or merely creates one on g6. White's resistance is: White seeks h4, Be2, and a slow bind. The line fails as a template when: Flank prevention without central activity can become self-restraint.

STORE THIS | A useful hook is one your pieces can attack.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

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4. What exact question decides the next move?

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ANSWER KEY

1. Nge2-g3 supports f5 and h5 ideas while leaving the f-pawn free, but the knight can become a target. 2. Use ...h5 and queen coordination to limit White's kingside space while preserving central play. 3. White seeks h4, Be2, and a slow bind. 4. Judge ...h5 by whether it fixes a target or merely creates one on g6. 5. Flank prevention without central activity can become self-restraint.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. e4 d6 5. Nge2 O-O 6. Ng3 e5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The Nge2 clamp



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

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SIDE TO MOVE

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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

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FAILURE MODE

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DECISION TEST

Ask: Judge ...h5 by whether it fixes a target or merely creates one on g6. Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

RULE | A useful hook is one your pieces can attack.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nge2 O-O 6. Ng3 e5 7. d5 h5 8. Bg5 Qe8



- Ng3: White reroutes a knight toward g3; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- e5: Black makes direct central contact and asks whether White will close, capture, or maintain tension.
- d5: White claims space or creates a break that changes Black's available time and squares.
- h5: Black gains or fixes kingside space and prepares line-opening contact for the pieces.
- Bg5: White changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- Qe8: Black coordinates several plans, but the queen's safety and the opponent's forcing reply must be checked.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Nge2-g3 supports f5 and h5 ideas while leaving the f-pawn free, but the knight can become a target.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Judge ...h5 by whether it fixes a target or merely creates one on g6. White's resistance is: White seeks h4, Be2, and a slow bind. The line fails as a template when: Flank prevention without central activity can become self-restraint.

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ANSWER KEY

1. Nge2-g3 supports f5 and h5 ideas while leaving the f-pawn free, but the knight can become a target. 2. Use ...h5 and queen coordination to limit White's kingside space while preserving central play. 3. White seeks h4, Be2, and a slow bind. 4. Judge ...h5 by whether it fixes a target or merely creates one on g6. 5. Flank prevention without central activity can become self-restraint.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Ng3 e5 7. d5 h5 8. Bg5 Qe8

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 061 Decode: Early Bg5

Prompt: Read the king placement before choosing which wing to open.

Recall: An unusual move matters through the plan it enables.

LESSON 062 Play: Early Bg5

Prompt: Read the king placement before choosing which wing to open.

Recall: An unusual move matters through the plan it enables.

LESSON 063 Decode: The Bd3 setup

Prompt: Decide whether opening the center exploits White's slower kingside development.

Recall: When White's pieces crowd one wing, open the center if your king is safer.

LESSON 064 Play: The Bd3 setup

Prompt: Decide whether opening the center exploits White's slower kingside development.

Recall: When White's pieces crowd one wing, open the center if your king is safer.

LESSON 065 Decode: The Nge2 clamp

Prompt: Judge ...h5 by whether it fixes a target or merely creates one on g6.

Recall: A useful hook is one your pieces can attack.

LESSON 066 Play: The Nge2 clamp

Prompt: Judge ...h5 by whether it fixes a target or merely creates one on g6.

Recall: A useful hook is one your pieces can attack.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's plan, White's counterplay, one candidate, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

Early Bg5

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Bg5 O-O 6. Qd2 c5 7. d5 e6

Decision: Read the king placement before choosing which wing to open.

Memory: An unusual move matters through the plan it enables.

CARD 2

The Bd3 setup

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Bd3 O-O 6. Nge2 e5 7. d5 c6 8. O-O cxd5 9. cxd5

Decision: Decide whether opening the center exploits White's slower kingside development.

Memory: When White's pieces crowd one wing, open the center if your king is safer.

CARD 3

The Nge2 clamp

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nge2 O-O 6. Ng3 e5 7. d5 h5 8. Bg5 Qe8

Decision: Judge ...h5 by whether it fixes a target or merely creates one on g6.

Memory: A useful hook is one your pieces can attack.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
061 Decode: Early Bg5	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
062 Play: Early Bg5	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
063 Decode: The Bd3 setup	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
064 Play: The Bd3 setup	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
065 Decode: The Nge2 clamp	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
066 Play: The Nge2 clamp	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name White's best counterplay, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.